

■ By Farzand Ahmed in Bhagalpur

■ October 27, 1989: A frenzied mob, guided by assistant sub-inspector of police Ramchandra Singh, massacres 116 Muslims in Logain village, 30 km from Bhagalpur town, throws the bodies in a well. Later, the bodies are fished out and buried in a nearby field.

■ July 7, 2007: Additional Sessions Judge S.N. Mishra awards life-term to 14 accused including Singh and village chowkidar Thakur Paswan, saying: "Since the crime, though serious, does not fall in the rarest of rare category, the convicts are sentenced to life imprisonment".

For many social and political activists in and around Bhagalpur, the ancient silk town in eastern Bihar which is now more known for mass blindings and periodic massacres, the July 7 verdict was "too little too late". But to the lone surviving couple in Logain, it means nothing. Living in a *marai* (a straw roof supported by bamboos but open from all sides), the ageing couple says the years gone by have made them immune to fear. After witnessing their



POLITICS OF CONVICTION

If anything, a Bhagalpur court's verdict on the Logain massacre following a long-drawn trial reopens old wounds and provides the JD(U)-BJP Government a lab for a new political experiment



daughter-in-law and three grandchildren as well as all their neighbours being hacked to death in broad daylight, Jalebi Khatoon, 70, and her husband Bidesi Mian, 75, feel they have seen the worst and there is nothing more to fear. The lone *marai* is just 30 km from Bhagalpur and the sentencing of 14 people including 12 fellow-villagers on charges of killing 116 people holds no meaning whatsoever to them. "How can this make a difference to our lot?" Jalebi quips philosophically. But in a neighbouring cluster, there is anger brewing. This is the place where

12 of the 14 convicts belong. "This has been done for political gain," said Shyama Devi, wife of one of the convicts, Kuldip Mandal. "Everyone knows that the killers were outsiders. Who will be responsible if people's anger spills over?" retorts Shyam Sunder Mandal, 37, a relative of Kuldip.

The 17-year-long trial and conviction has not only reopened old wounds but also has an emerging political gameplan behind it. Eager to create a new social equation in the state, the JD(U)-BJP Government is using Bhagalpur and Logain as laboratories

for a new political experiment. The Bhagalpur riots had erupted during the Ram Shila puja procession on October 24, 1989. It was in the aftermath of these riots that the Congress was wiped out from the Centre in November 1989 polls and also in the state assembly elections that followed the next year. Lalu Prasad Yadav created a Muslim-Yadav votebank that helped him rule Bihar for 15 years. Chief Minister Nitish Kumar now wants to borrow a leaf out of Lalu's strategy book to create a Muslim-Koeri-Kurmi combine which could turn out to be invincible for many